excitement at Old Trafford during my first season as a regular. I'd wake up every morning hardly able to believe what was going on around me. I'd drive into training, thinking to myself: *I'm a first-team player. I'm doing my work on the main field at the Cliff. I've got my own spot in the car park, with my initials there in white paint*. When I went to the training ground for the first time as a boy, those white lines marked out with the initials of the United players I idolized seemed to represent everything I dreamed of achieving for myself. Now, I belonged and it might have been easy to get swept away with it all. People at the club, though, and the manager in particular, didn't let that happen. They didn't suddenly start behaving differently towards me and the other young lads just because it said 'DB' on the tarmac and me, Gary and the rest were on the teamsheet every week.

I was excited every morning about going in to train with Eric Cantona, too. We'd made a good start without him during that 1995/96 season, but the captain being back at the club and back in the team counted for a lot. I don't know about the other players but, if Eric was in the dressing room, I'd find myself watching him: checking what he was doing, trying to workout exactly how he prepared for a game. If he was there, I hardly seemed to notice anything else that was going on. I've always been a fan: a Manchester United fan. And I still am. When I had my first chance to go into the dressing rooms at Old Trafford as a boy, I asked where Bryan Robson sat and then walked across to sit there myself. I was the same about Eric and couldn't quite get over the fact that I was sitting alongside him in the build-up to games, never mind that we'd be playing together later that afternoon.

We played some great soccer that season. I remember one night at Old Trafford when we played Bolton and won 3–0. It could have been ten. Paul Scholes scored twice, Giggsy got the other and we absolutely battered them. When the team was flying, Eric Cantona was usually at the heart of it. The difficult games, though, were the ones in which he really left his mark. After Christmas, we had a run of 1–0 wins. United supporters didn't even need to check: it was always Eric who scored. I remember one game against QPR down at Loftus Road. We were terrible and they were winning 1–0. I'd actually been substituted and the injury time at the end just dragged on and on. The home fans were going mad and then Eric arrived in the penalty area right on cue to equalize. Goals like that—results like that—turn a whole season.

We spent month after month chasing Newcastle United, who were twelve points ahead of us going into 1996. We went up to St James' Park in the spring and Eric—who else—scored the only goal. From then on, we knew